

THE RISE AND FALL OF THE OTTOMAN EMPIRE

AN ENDURING POWER THAT DOMINATED IN EUROPE AND THE MIDDLE EAST FOR NEARLY 500 YEARS

The long decline of the Ottoman Empire in the 19th century disguised the fact that for 450 years after its emergence in about 1300, it was not just one of the most dynamic and sophisticated polities in the world, but also one of the largest. It dwarfed its European and Middle Eastern rivals.

At its height, toward the end of the 17th century, the Ottoman Empire stretched from the gates of Vienna to the Indian Ocean, and from the Crimea to Algiers. Though the Mongol leader Timur had checked Ottoman ambitions in the early 15th century, once Murad I took the throne in 1413, the expansion program was vigorously renewed. His son, Mehmed II (r. 1451–81), extended Ottoman rule across the Balkans and seized Constantinople (Istanbul) in a blaze of conquest. Under Selim I (r. 1512–20), the Safavids were contained at

Caldiran and much of the Middle East and North Africa was conquered. Suleiman the Magnificent (r. 1520–66) expanded Ottoman territories deep into Hungary and almost as far as the Atlantic. Faced with such potency, the Christian West could do little. Enormously rich, technologically advanced, and buoyed by its leadership of the Muslim world, Ottoman power seemed irresistible. The empire's decline after the failure of the siege of Vienna in 1683 was the result less of internal weakness than of the growing strength of its European opponents.

ATLANTIC OCEAN

PORTUGAL
Lisbon
SPAIN
Madrid
MOROCCO
Fez
Oran

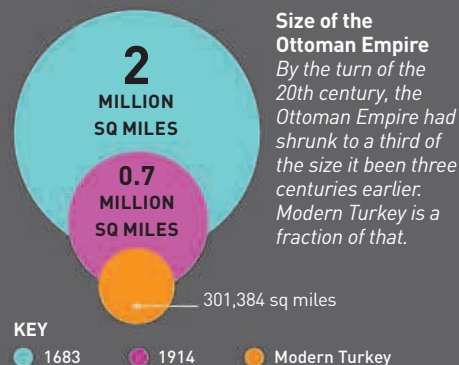
FORMIDABLE OPPONENTS

The Ottoman state began as a small frontier principality preying on Christian Byzantium. Under a succession of 14th-century warrior-sultans, a series of rapid conquests were launched, notably at Kosovo in 1389, when a combined Christian–Balkan force was defeated. Bayezid I (r. 1389–1402) exploited this victory by annexing Bulgaria and invading Hungary. Ottoman success was based on a highly trained army. The most feared troops, the janissaries, were recruited from the conquered peoples of the Balkans, converted to Islam. In addition, Ottoman artillery in the 15th and 16th centuries was among the most destructive in the world.



1481 From a small nucleus c. 1300, the Ottomans went on to conquer a vast area, covering much of Anatolia and the area around the Black Sea by 1481.

KEY
 Empire at 1300
 Empire at 1481



16th-century Empire

At its peak, the Ottoman Empire was not just a land power—its navy dominated the eastern Mediterranean and the maritime routes with the Indian Ocean. It challenged not merely European but its Middle Eastern rivals, too: Mamluk Egypt, conquered in 1517, and Safavid Persia, an equally dynamic and sophisticated state.

